

Q I've got an early ultrasound appointment because I've been bleeding. Should I rest until then?

It's estimated that 10 percent of women experience some spotting or bleeding in the very earliest stages of pregnancy and most of them go on to have full-term, healthy babies.

While you're waiting for your ultrasound appointment, avoid heavy lifting and sexual intercourse and try to rest as much as possible, but don't fret about doing so—as long as your normal day is uneventful, there's no reason to imagine that it will make your bleeding worse, and you can continue as usual. Keep well hydrated and try to eat normally (even if you don't feel like eating). If your bleeding worsens, call your doctor and ask for advice. He or she may ask you to go to your local emergency room so that you are seen immediately. If your ultrasound shows



Six-week ultrasound The embryo will only be between $\frac{1}{4}$ – $\frac{3}{8}$ in (5–9 mm) long at this stage of pregnancy.

that things are normal, you'll be sent home. Usually the bleeding will stop within 10 days, but if it doesn't, call the hospital. If the ultrasound shows that something is wrong, your sonographer will advise you about what to do next.

Q Can I take someone with me to my ultrasounds, and can I have a picture?

Most doctors recommend that you have someone with you to enjoy the experience of seeing your baby, but also so that you have support if something is not as you'd hoped or expected. It can be useful to have someone there to ask questions. Your partner, or a close family member or friend are the obvious choices. Sonographers are usually very happy to give you a photograph taken from the ultrasound. There may be a small charge for this—check at the reception desk beforehand.

Early ultrasounds at six to seven weeks are usually transvaginal. Vaginal ultrasounds give a clearer picture at this stage than transabdominal ones and also use **sound waves**.

Q What's an EPU? My doctor mentioned it if I need an early ultrasound.

An EPU is an Early Pregnancy Unit (sometimes known as an Early Pregnancy Assessment Unit or Early Pregnancy Assessment Center; EPAU and EPAC respectively). It is a specialized unit in a hospital dedicated to detecting and treating concerns in early pregnancy. If you need to have an early ultrasound and your local hospital has one of these units, this is probably where you'll go. Not all hospitals have an EPU, in which case early ultrasounds are performed in the regular prenatal hospital clinic. There are often strict criteria for referral (from your doctor) to the EPU, including how far along your pregnancy is ("early" usually means within the first trimester, but not usually earlier than seven weeks along), whether or not you've had a positive pregnancy test recently, and the nature of your concern. EPUs can be reluctant to give women an ultrasound to assess the viability of their pregnancy if there's no immediate cause to suspect that the pregnancy is anything but viable. Straightforward referrals include a family history of twins, having period like bleeding, or spotting that has lasted over a week.

Q I've been having fertility treatment. When will I have my first ultrasound?

Systems differ depending on the doctor. You may have an ultrasound as early as three weeks pregnant to locate the embryo sac in your uterus. Other doctors wait until you have a positive pregnancy test result and give you an ultrasound at around six weeks pregnant (about four weeks after collecting your eggs), because it's around this time that the ultrasound can detect your baby's heartbeat. If it appears that your treatment has been successful, you'll have an ultrasound two weeks or so later (around eight weeks pregnant) to check that the embryo is growing as expected. You will probably then stop going to your fertility specialist and be asked to make an appointment with your OB/GYN so that you can start prenatal care.

Q I don't want to wait for my 12-week ultrasound to see my baby. Can I pay to have a private ultrasound?

Absolutely. You can pay for an ultrasound from as early as seven weeks gestation (before this, there is very little an ultrasound can show).

Most sonographers will begin by giving you an abdominal ultrasound (using the handheld scanner over your growing baby), but at such an early stage in pregnancy, it's possible that he or she may switch to using a vaginal ultrasound to get a better picture of your baby. In this case, a long, thin sonograph device is inserted into your vagina to get closer to your uterus.

Q Why would I need an early ultrasound?

If you struggled to get pregnant, have a history of recurrent miscarriages or a multiple pregnancy, are at risk of an ectopic pregnancy, have an incompetent cervix, or have had some vaginal bleeding or uterine pain unrelated to your last menstrual period, your doctor may refer you for an ultrasound at around seven weeks pregnant. Similarly if you already know that you suffer from fibroids or you're suspected to be carrying twins or multiples, your doctor will want to check that everything is as it should be.